

Education Indicator

EDUCATION AND LEARNING OUTCOMES

School leaver destinations

In 2023 there were 64,303 school leavers. Of these, 58.1% (37,385 school leavers) enrolled in tertiary education during 2024.

Indicator description

Tertiary education destinations of school leavers one year after leaving school. This indicator describes the destinations in 2024 of the cohort of school leavers who left school in 2023. This school leaver cohort is a year behind the other school leaver cohorts reported on in indicators published at the same time as school leavers have the full year, after leaving school, to move into tertiary training or education.

Why transition to tertiary education is important

Each year, around 60,000 students leave school and move on to further education, workplace training, employment or go overseas.

This indicator follows the destinations of domestic school leavers into formal tertiary education, including industry training. The tertiary education sector is a diverse sector. It includes community education courses as well as advanced postgraduate degrees. It provides education for a diverse range of learners, from school leavers to mid-career workers, the unemployed, international students, and those pursuing an interest, hobby, or more social interaction. Enrolment in tertiary education indicates the extent to which New Zealanders are developing the skills needed for a modern knowledge economy and society.

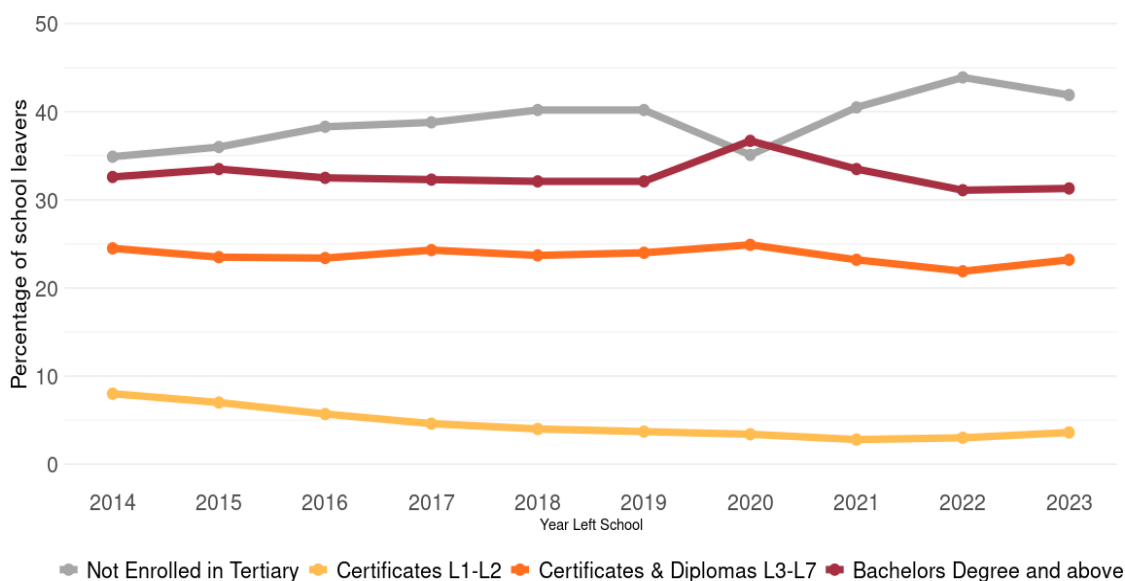
How are we going

Of the 64,303 domestic students who left school in 2023, 58.1% enrolled in tertiary education during 2024. This was an increase of 2.0 percentage points compared to the 2022 leaving cohort who enrolled in tertiary education in 2023 (56.1%).

Compared to 2022 school leavers, the 2023 school leavers were more likely to participate in higher levels of tertiary education (Certificate Level 3 and above). The proportion of school leavers enrolled in bachelor's level and above increased by 0.2 percentage points to 31.3% and leavers enrolled in Level 3 to 7 certificates and diplomas increased 1.3 percentage points to 23.2%. The proportion of leavers enrolled in Level 1 and 2 certificates increased 0.6 percentage points to 3.6% (see Figure 1).

During 2024, participation in the labour force was lower relative to 2023 and 2022. The labour force participation rate in the year ending December 2024 was 50.9% for 15 to 19 year-olds and 80.9% for 20 to 24 year-olds, down by 3.8 and 1.7 percentage points respectively from the gains in 2023.¹² It is likely that a tight labour market led to an increase in job uncertainty, squeezing out the less experienced youth. Additionally, increases to the cost of living and a broader slowdown in economic activity led to more leavers opting for tertiary education in 2024.³ In times of labour market uncertainty, education is often seen as a safer long-term investment prompting a higher proportion of young people to remain in school longer and pursue further studies.

Figure 1: The proportion of leavers in certificates and diplomas L3-L7 one year after leaving school increased for 2023 school leavers



Previous research from the Ministry of Education indicated that qualifications gained at school have the highest association with entry into higher levels of tertiary education, and learners' success in school was strongly associated with passing most first year courses across all levels of study.⁴

School leavers with University Entrance (UE) had the highest participation in tertiary study compared to school leavers with lower-level qualifications. Around one-fifth (18.4%) did not enrol in tertiary study in 2024. The likelihood of school leavers going onto tertiary study related to the level of NCEA or UE they achieved (see Figure 2):

- Of the 24,840 school leavers with UE in 2023, 75.4% were enrolled in bachelor's level or above and 6.1% in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 during 2024.
- Of the 9,135 school leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above (without UE) in 2023, 7.2% were enrolled in bachelor's level or above and 41.3% were enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 the

¹ The labour force participation rate is the proportion of people in employment or unemployed out of the total population.

² [Household Labour Force Survey New Zealand \(Annual-Dec\)](#)

³ GDP decreases 1.0 percent in the September 2024 quarter ([Stats NZ](#))

⁴ Earle, D. (2018). Going on to, and achieving in, higher-level tertiary education. Ministry of Education.



following year. Over half (50.6%) of school leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above (without UE) were not enrolled in tertiary study.

- Of the 14,565 school leavers with NCEA Level 2 in 2023, 4.4% were enrolled in bachelor's level or above and 42.7% were enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 the following year. Over half (50.9%) of school leavers with NCEA Level 2 were not enrolled in tertiary study.
- Of the 5,869 school leavers with NCEA Level 1 in 2023, the following year 0.7% were enrolled in bachelor's level or above, 30.7% were enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 and 9.6% were enrolled in level 1 or 2 certificates. Nearly two-thirds (59%) of school leavers with NCEA Level 1 were not enrolled in tertiary study.
- Of the 9,894 school leavers without a qualification in 2023, the following year 0.6% were enrolled in bachelor's level or above, 16.3% were enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 and 13.9% were enrolled in level 1 or 2 certificates. Over two-thirds (69.2%) of the school leavers without a qualification were not enrolled in tertiary study.

Figure 2: Participation in tertiary study in 2024 for 2023 school leavers



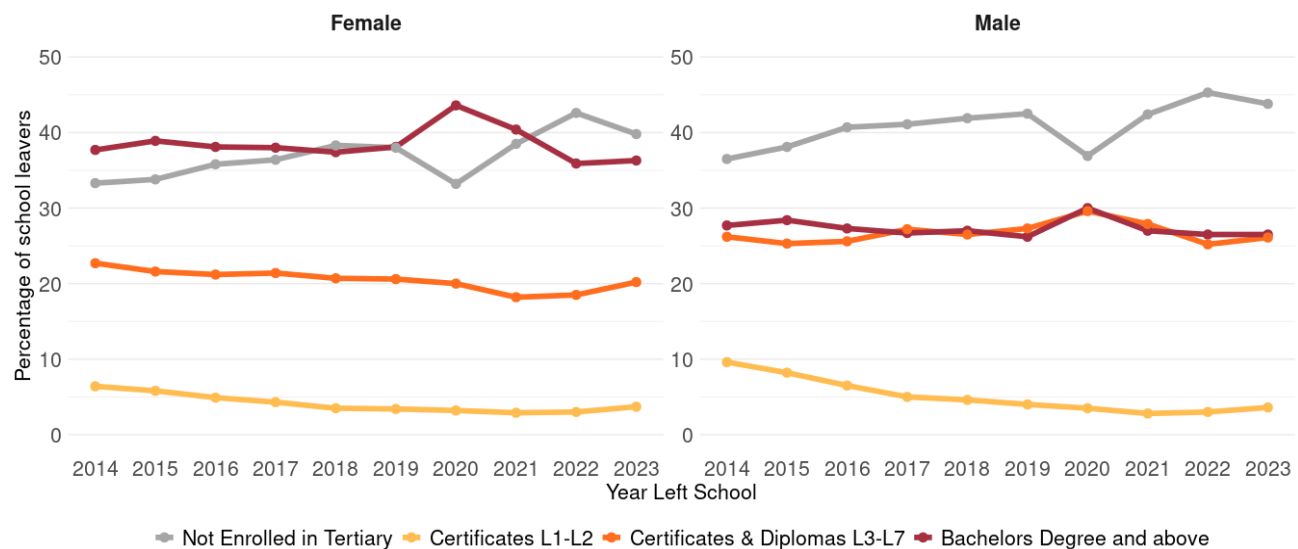
Gender

Female school leavers were more likely to progress to tertiary education in the year after leaving school than male school leavers. During 2024, 60.2% of female school leavers from the 2023 leaver cohort were enrolled in tertiary education compared to 56.2% of male school leavers. Compared to the 2022 leaver cohort, the proportion of school leavers enrolled in tertiary education increased by 2.8 percentage points for female and 1.5 percentage points for male school leavers.

In 2024, female school leavers were more likely than male leavers to enrol in bachelor's degrees and above (36.3% and 26.5% respectively). About 20.2% of female leavers were enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 compared to 26.1% of male leavers, while 3.7% of female leavers and 3.6% of male leavers were enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2 (see Figure 3).



Figure 3: Female school leavers were more likely to progress to bachelor's degrees and above in the year after leaving school



Ethnicity⁵

For all ethnic groups, whether they went onto tertiary study, and at which level, was related to what school qualification they attained.

Research published by NZQA showed that on average Māori and Pacific students in Year 13 who attained NCEA Level 3 were less likely to attain University Entrance, the minimum qualification for direct entry into a New Zealand university, compared to their Asian and European/Pākehā counterparts. The data showed that there were differences in both the structure and content of the assessment programmes of those who both attained NCEA Level 3 and UE, and those who did not. For example, to be awarded UE, students must attain enough credits in three UE approved subjects, however rates of entry into approved UE subjects were lower for Māori and Pacific students (NZQA, 2022). This illustrates some of the inequities in the system.

Māori school leavers

Of the Māori school leavers who left school in 2023, 44.8% were enrolled in tertiary study in 2024, up 4.3 percentage points from the participation rate of Māori school leavers in 2022. Looking at participation in education by highest attainment of school leavers who identify as Māori (Figure 4) we see:

- In 2023, 2,975 Māori school leavers attained UE. In 2024, 68.0% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above, 10.0% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 and 0.2% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 2,635 Māori school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 (without UE). In 2024, 5.5% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees or above, 35.0% enrolled in certificate and diplomas at levels 3-7, and 1.4% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 4,176 Māori school leavers attained NCEA Level 2. In 2024, 2.3% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above, 35.1% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at level 3 or above, and 3.6% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.

⁵ Total response ethnicity counts school leavers who identify with more than one ethnic group in each of these ethnic groups. For the New Zealand total, individuals are counted only once.



- In 2023, 2,163 Māori school leavers attained NCEA Level 1. In 2024, 23.2% of these leavers enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 and 13.7% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 4,369 Māori school leavers left school without a qualification. In 2024, 31.1% of these leavers enrolled in tertiary study, either in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 (14%) or certificates at levels 1-2 (17.1%).

The proportion of Māori school leavers not participating in education in their first year after leaving school increased from 45.0% of 2014 school leavers to 59.5% of 2022 school leavers but then decreased to 55.2% of 2023 school leavers.

Figure 4: Māori school leavers' tertiary destinations in 2024



Māori and language of learning⁶

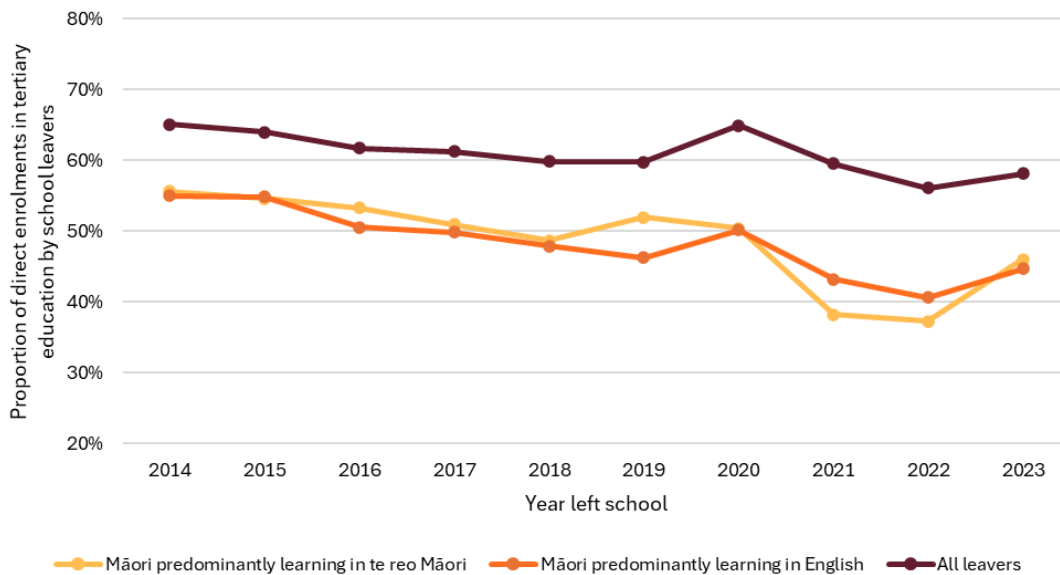
Note that when looking at statistics based on small populations, such as the small number of school leavers who learned predominantly in te reo Māori, a small change in numbers can result in a relatively large change in proportions and therefore relatively large fluctuations from year to year.

Figure 5 shows the trend in tertiary participation for Māori by language of learning. Tertiary enrolment rates for Māori school leavers predominantly learning in te reo and Māori school leavers predominantly learning in English are similar, with an increase in enrolment rates in 2024 by 2023 Māori school leavers from both groups after year-on-year declines since 2020. For Māori leavers who left school in 2019, a higher proportion of those predominantly learning in te reo enrolled in tertiary education in 2020 compared to their peers predominantly learning in English. The pattern changes for tertiary enrolments for these groups of learners suggest possible barriers to tertiary enrolments. Enrolments rates for both groups of learners are below what they were in 2014.

⁶ The predominant language of learning is the one that school leavers are learning in at least 51% of the time.



Figure 5: Proportion of school leavers who enrolled in tertiary education within one year of leaving school by language of learning, 2014-2023



Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori

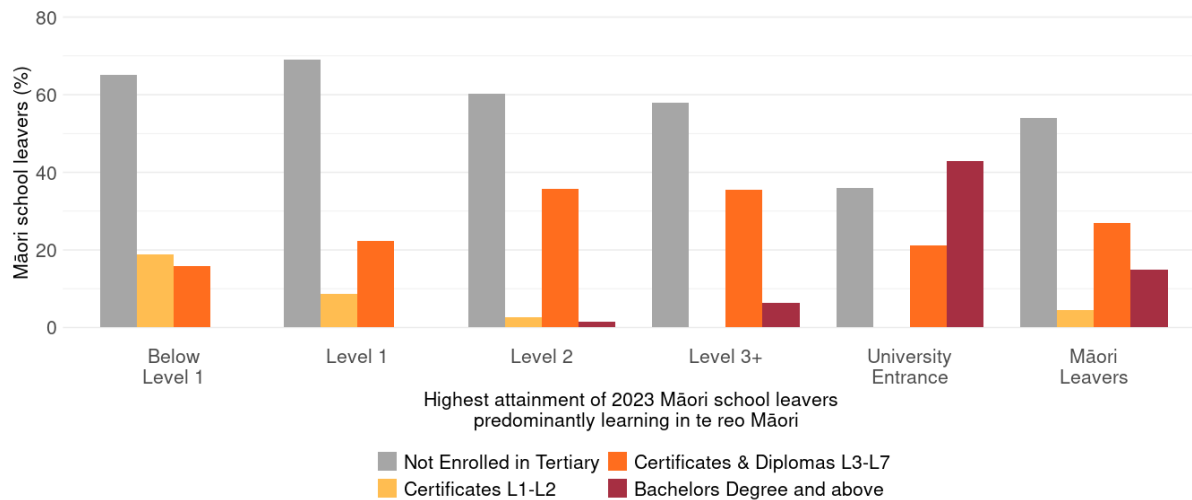
Of the 16,318 ākonga Māori who left school in 2023, 5.3% (867 Māori school leavers) were predominantly learning in te reo Māori. The number of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori has increased 81.4% since 2014 (478 Māori school leavers in 2014).

In 2023, 46% of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori when they left school were participating in tertiary education in 2024. This was an increase of 8.8 percentage points from 2022 school leavers. Since 2014, participation in tertiary education has decreased by 9.6 percentage points (see Figure 5).

Higher attainment in school creates more options in tertiary study for school leavers. Among the 2023 Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori who left school with UE, 64% participated in higher tertiary (diplomas and degrees) in 2024, with 42.8% enrolled in bachelor's degrees or above and 21.2% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 in 2024 (see Figure 6).



Figure 6: Tertiary destinations in 2024 of Māori school leavers (from 2023) who predominantly learnt in te reo Māori, by highest school leaver attainment



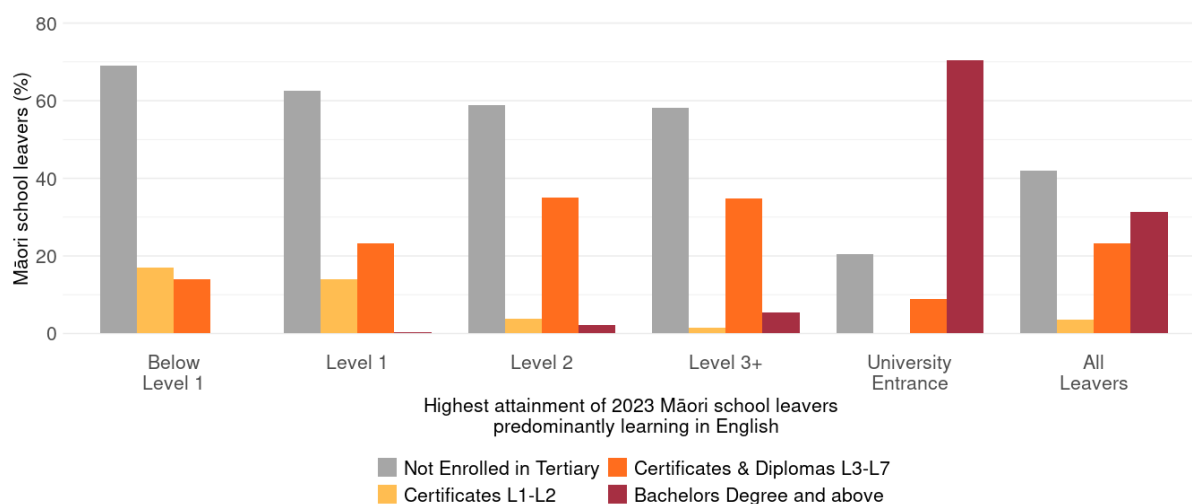
Māori predominantly learning in English

Of the 16,318 ākonga Māori who left school in 2023, 94.7% (15,451 Māori school leavers) were predominantly learning in English. The number of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English has increased 20.9% since 2014 (12,777 Māori school leavers in 2014).

In 2023, 44.7% of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English when they left school were participating in tertiary education in 2024. This was an increase of 4.1 percentage points from 2022 school leavers. Since 2014, participation in tertiary education has decreased by 10.3 percentage points.

Among the 2023 Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English and who left school with UE, 79.5% participated in tertiary study in 2024, with 70.4% enrolled in bachelor's degrees or above and 8.9% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 (see Figure 7).

Figure 7: Tertiary destinations in 2024 of Māori school leavers (from 2023) who predominantly learnt in English, by highest school leaver attainment



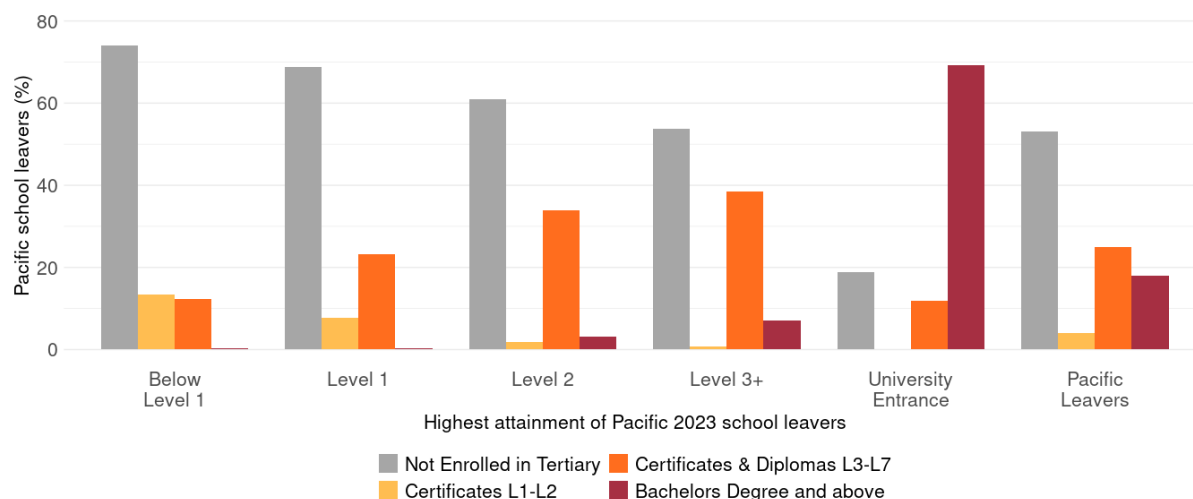
Pacific school leavers

School leavers in 2023 who identified as Pacific were more likely to participate in tertiary study in 2024 compared to their peers who left school in 2022. For Pacific school leavers who left school in 2023, 46.9% were enrolled in tertiary study in 2024, up 5.0 percentage points from the participation rate of Pacific school leavers who left school in 2022. Looking at participation in tertiary study, by highest attainment in school (Figure 8) we see:

- In 2023, 1,845 Pacific school leavers attained UE. Of these, 69.2% enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above, 11.9% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 and 0.2% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 1,923 Pacific school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 (without UE). In 2024, 7% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees or above, 38.5% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7, and 0.7% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 2,057 Pacific school leavers attained NCEA Level 2. In 2024, 3.2% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above, 33.8% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at level 3 or above, and 1.9% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 874 Pacific school leavers attained NCEA Level 1. In 2024, 0.3% enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above, 23.2% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7, and 7.7% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 1,534 Pacific school leavers left school without a qualification. In 2024, 25.7% of these leavers enrolled in tertiary study, either in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 (12.3%), or certificates at levels 1-2 (13.4%). 0.3% enrolled in a bachelor's degree or above.

The proportion of Pacific school leavers not participating in education in their first year after leaving school increased from 41.2% of 2014 school leavers to 58.1% of 2022 school leavers but then decreased by 5.0 percentage points to 53.1% for 2023 school leavers.

Figure 8: Pacific school leavers' tertiary destinations in 2024, by highest school leaver attainment



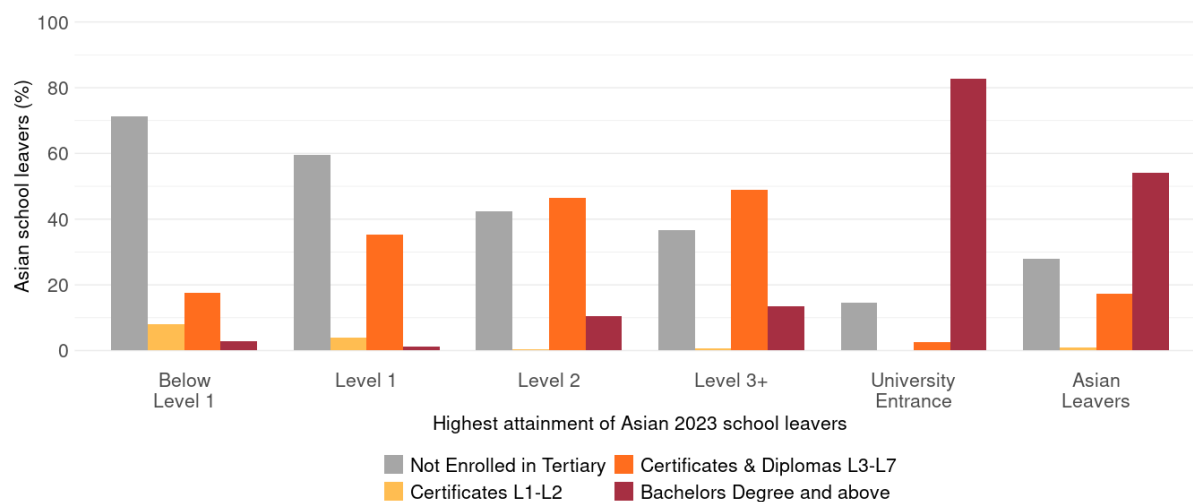
Asian school leavers

School leavers in 2023 who identified as Asian were less likely to participate in tertiary study in 2024 compared to their peers who left school in 2022. For Asian school leavers who left school in 2023, 72.2% were enrolled in tertiary study in 2024, down 0.7 percentage points from the participation rates of Asian school leavers who left school in 2022. Looking at participation in education, by highest attainment in school (Figure 9) we see:

- In 2023, 5,571 Asian school leavers attained UE. In 2024, 82.6% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above and 2.7% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7.
- In 2023, 1,041 Asian school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 (without UE). In 2024, 13.6% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees or above, 49.0% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7, and 0.7% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 1,347 Asian school leavers attained NCEA Level 2. In 2024, 10.6% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above, 46.4% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at level 3 or above, and 0.5% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 450 Asian school leavers attained NCEA Level 1. In 2024, 1.1% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above, 35.3% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7, and 4.1% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 678 Asian school leavers left school without a qualification. In 2024, 25.7% of these leavers enrolled in tertiary study, either in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 (17.7%), or certificates at levels 1-2 (8.0%).

The proportion of Asian school leavers not participating in education in their first year after leaving school increased from 19.6% of 2014 school leavers to 27.8% of 2023 school leavers.

Figure 9: Asian school leavers' tertiary destinations in 2024, by highest school leaver attainment



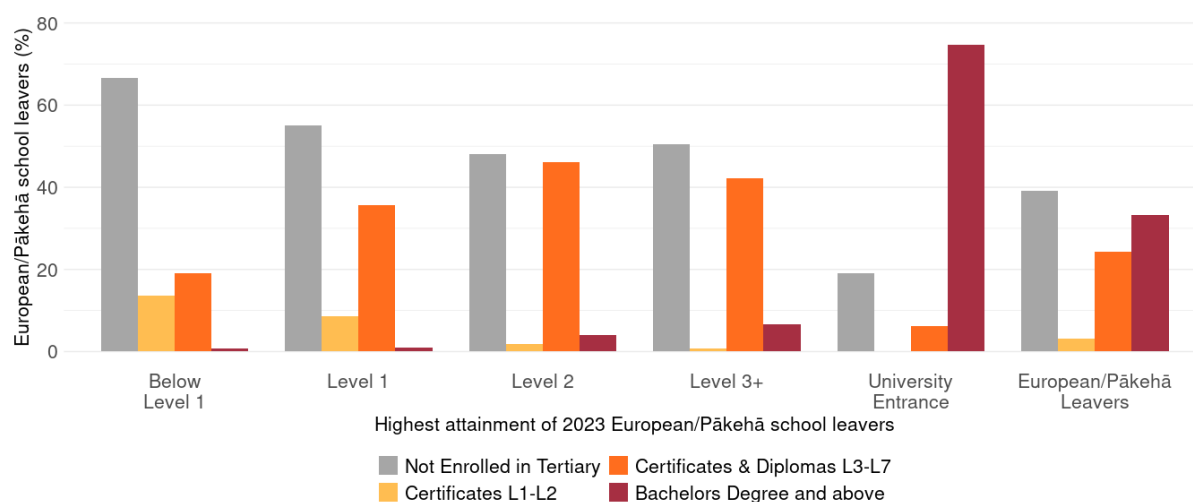
European/Pākehā school leavers

School leavers in 2023 who identified as European/Pākehā were more likely to participate in tertiary study in 2024 compared to their peers who left school in 2022. For European/Pākehā school leavers who left school in 2023, 60.8% were enrolled in tertiary study in 2024, up 1.3 percentage points from the participation rate of European/Pākehā school leavers who left school in 2022. Looking at participation in education by highest attainment in school (Figure 10) we see:

- In 2023, 16,928 European/Pākehā school leavers attained UE. In 2024, 74.6% of these leavers enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above, 6.2% enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 and 0.1% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 5,103 European/Pākehā school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 (without UE). In 2024, 42.1% of these leavers enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7, 6.7% enrolled in bachelor's degrees or above, and 0.7% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 9,461 European/Pākehā school leavers attained NCEA Level 2. In 2024, 46.2% of these leavers enrolled in certificates and diplomas at level 3 or above, 1.8% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2, and 4% enrolled in bachelor's degrees and above.
- In 2023, 3,573 European/Pākehā school leavers attained NCEA Level 1. In 2024, 35.6% of these leavers enrolled in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 and 8.5% enrolled in certificates at levels 1-2.
- In 2023, 5,222 European/Pākehā school leavers left school without a qualification. In 2024, 32.7% of these leavers enrolled in tertiary study, either in certificates and diplomas at levels 3-7 (19%) or certificates at levels 1-2 (13.7%).

The proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers not participating in education in their first year after leaving school increased from 33.7% of 2014 school leavers to 40.5% for 2022 school leavers but then decreased 1.3 percentage points to 39.2% for 2023 school leavers.

Figure 10: European/Pākehā school leavers' tertiary destinations in 2024, by highest school leaver attainment

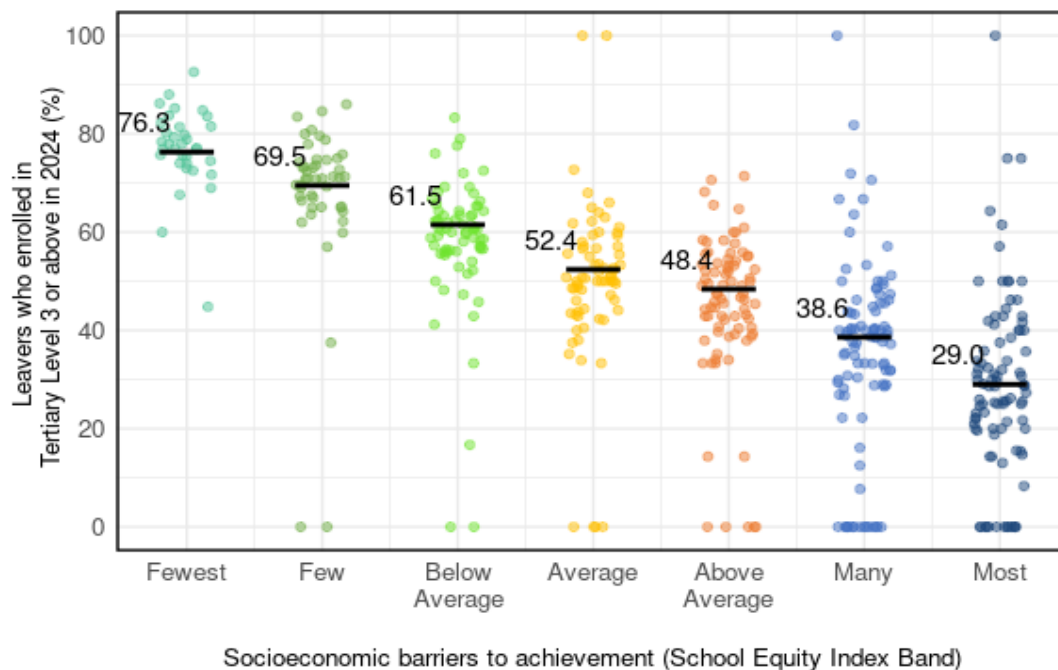


Socioeconomic barriers⁷

At a system level, schools where students experience more socioeconomic barriers to achievement have lower tertiary participation rates and a higher variability of participation rates within the School Equity Index Bands.

Figure 11 shows the association between participation in tertiary education for school leavers and socioeconomic background. In 2024, schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement had 76.3% 2023 school leavers enrol in tertiary study at Level 3 or higher, compared to 29.0% of leavers from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement.

Figure 11: Rates of participation in tertiary education in 2024 for 2023 school leavers, by School Equity Index Bands



Trends by School Equity Index Groups

School leavers from schools where students had fewer barriers (few or the fewest) to achievement were more likely to enrol in tertiary education. From the 2023 leaver cohort, 73.5% of school leavers where students had fewer barriers to achievement enrolled in tertiary education during 2024. This compares with 58.6% of leavers from schools where students had moderate (below average, average or above average) barriers to achievement and 41.7% of leavers from schools with more (many or the most) barriers to achievement.

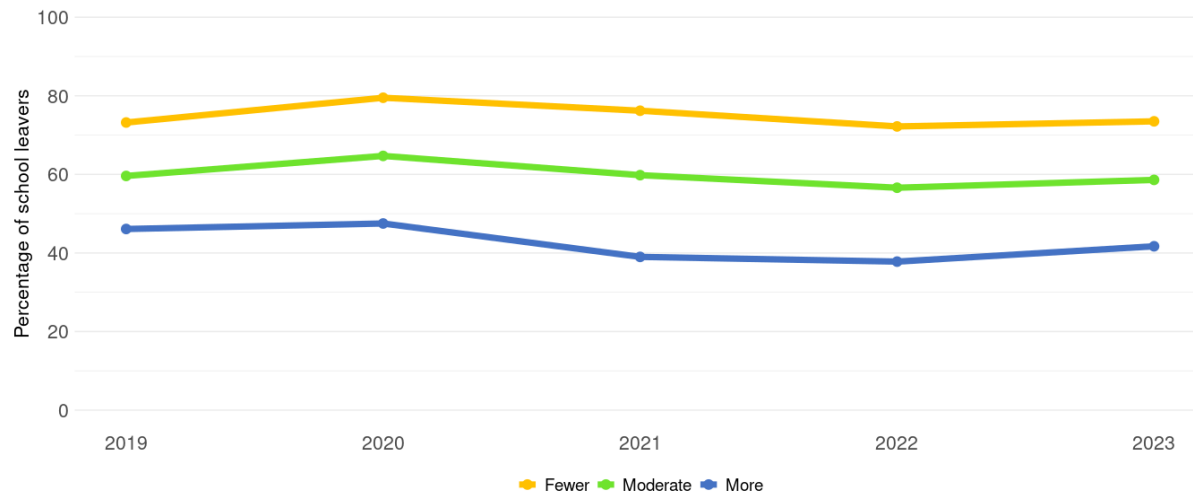
Compared to 2022 school leavers, enrolment in tertiary education in the following year by 2023 school leavers increased by 1.2 percentage points for school leavers from schools where students had fewer barriers to achievement. Enrolment in tertiary study for school leavers from schools where students had moderate barriers increased by 2.0 percentage points and by 4.0 percentage points for school leavers from schools where students had more barriers to achievement.

⁷ For more on the socioeconomic measures used in this indicator see the section at the end of this report.



Since 2020, tertiary enrolment rates have been decreasing across schools from all socioeconomic groups as shown in Figure 12. The biggest decrease was in schools where students had moderate barriers to achievement where the proportion of students enrolling in tertiary study decreased by 6.2 percentage points.

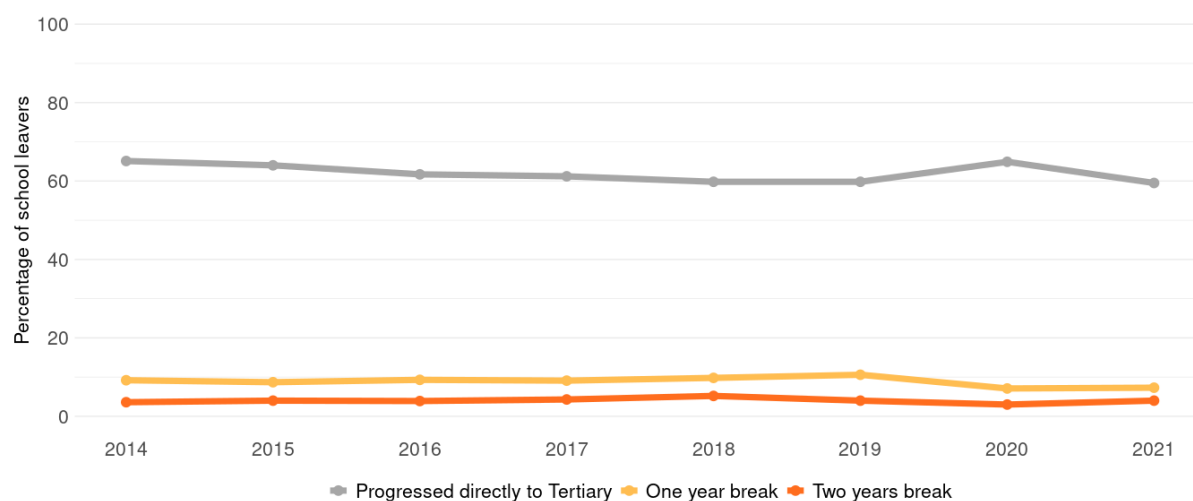
Figure 12: Direct enrolment in tertiary education for school leavers by socioeconomic barriers to achievement (School Equity Index Groups)



Further education in the first three years after leaving school

Some students have a gap of more than one year between leaving school and enrolling in tertiary education. From the 2021 leaver cohort (the latest cohort for which we have three years of destination data): 59.5% enrolled in tertiary study within one year after leaving school (direct transition); 7.3% enrolled for the first time two years after leaving school; 4% enrolled for the first time three years after leaving school; and 29.2% had no enrolment in a tertiary course within three years of leaving school (see Figure 13).

Figure 13: Most school leavers made a direct transition to tertiary education



About equity index reporting

The Ministry has developed a new method of reporting on socioeconomic trends in education statistics called School Equity Index Bands and Groups. These categories estimate the extent to which, on average, students at a school face socioeconomic barriers that could get in the way of their school achievement. There are seven School Equity Index Bands, each containing approximately the same number of schools. Schools are placed into a band based on their Equity Index number. There are three School Equity Index Groups formed by collapsing the seven School Equity Index Bands as indicated in the following diagram. More information on this reporting method can be found on the Ministry's [Education Counts website](#).

Schooling Equity Index Number:



School Equity Index Band:

Fewest	Few	Below Average	Average	Above Average	Many	Most

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

School Equity Index Group:

Fewer	Moderate	More

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

Where to find out more

To obtain more information about student attainment see:

- [Tracked Year 11 cohort – Attainment timeframes for Level 2 certificate](#)
- [School leaver pathways](#)
- [School leavers attainment](#)

References

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